From “Problem Student” to Contextual Learner: Deconstructing Behavioral Stereotypes Through Classroom Observation

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Deconstructing Bias — Reflective Paper

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This paper examines a bias I have carried into classroom practice: the stereotype that some students are inherently "difficult," "off-task," or "behavior problems." For this assignment, I focus on students in my elementary practicum placement and analyze in-person classroom interactions documented through direct observation during spring 2026. I chose this setting because it provides concrete, lived observational material from my actual work as an educator-in-training, and because the moments I am analyzing were moments I participated in—not moments I watched from the outside.

The specific bias under investigation is the tendency to read visible frustration, noise, avoidance, or emotional escalation as evidence of fixed student deficiency. My guiding question is: **How does observing students who might otherwise be labeled as difficult or off-task challenge the stereotype that behavior problems are fixed traits rather than responses to confusion, frustration, and insufficient support?**

My central claim is that what looks like "bad behavior" is often better understood as a contextual response to unclear expectations, cognitive overload, time pressure, or insufficient instructional scaffolding. When the instructional conditions change, student behavior changes too—and that shift is precisely what deconstructs the myth of the fixed "problem student."

Autobiographical Grounding: Naming the Bias

This paper is not written from a neutral position. I am writing as a student teacher who is simultaneously learning classroom management and learning to question the interpretive habits I bring into that work. The bias I am examining is not only something I have observed in others; it is a habit of interpretation that I recognize in my own instincts and that I need to examine honestly.

Talusan (2022) describes identity-conscious practice as the ongoing work of noticing which assumptions we carry and how they shape what we see in students—not a one-time confrontation but a repeatable discipline. That framing captures something true about my starting point. The stereotype I am interrogating—that certain students are naturally disruptive, lazy, or unmotivated—is not a belief I hold consciously. It is a reflex shaped by years of schooling in which compliance read as competence and visible struggle read as character deficit.

I grew up in a context where students who moved efficiently through instructions were read as "good," and students who needed more time, more explanation, or more emotional support were quietly sorted into a different category—not always explicitly, but through the texture of how teachers responded to them. As a course instructor reflected in a pre-service teacher education seminar, "There is only so much you can hide from your kids" (Social Class seminar, March 23, 2026)—and that extends in both directions: students absorb the ways teachers see them, and teachers absorb the frameworks their own schooling used to sort people. I absorbed those frameworks without fully realizing it.

Part of why I am drawn to examining behavioral stereotypes specifically is that I have already caught myself, more than once, having a first instinctive reaction to a student's behavior before I have asked what is underneath it. This is the kind of socially learned bias that is easy to carry invisibly into the classroom—not out of malice, but out of the way schooling conditions us to read behavior. Naming it is the first step toward not reproducing it.

Observation Context

The observational material for this paper comes from direct observation during my elementary school practicum in spring 2026. The specific observations that ground this paper took place across several in-person sessions in a K–5 setting. I was present in my role as a student teacher, which means I was not observing from the outside—I was inside the instructional space, co-teaching and facilitating alongside the classroom teacher and mentor.

The primary focal setting is a grade 4 computer science classroom during a Minecraft Education coding challenge lesson (March 12, 2026). The lesson required students to program an agent through a multi-step sequence—a high-cognitive-demand task involving spatial reasoning, sequential logic, and sustained focus over a class period. This context is analytically useful precisely because it is the kind of task where frustration, noise, and apparent off-task behavior become visible quickly.

A secondary observational context comes from a college-level EDU 442 seminar (March 23, 2026) in which pre-service teachers and instructors facilitated a structured discussion on class, systemic inequity, and pedagogy. While that setting is different in level and format, it illuminates the structural framing that undergirds behavioral stereotypes—particularly the ways that class-based inequity shapes what "engaged" and "off-task" look like in the first place.

Ethically, all student identifiers are removed. Students are referred to generically throughout. The paper uses only the observational details necessary to illustrate the interpretive argument.

Myth vs. Reality: Core Analysis

The myth. Some students are "problem students" because they are naturally disruptive, unmotivated, or unwilling to follow directions. This belief—what Annamma, Connor, and Ferri (2013) describe as part of the broader apparatus through which schools label, sort, and punish students—treats behavior as a window into a student's fixed character rather than as a response to conditions. DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) shows that these labels are not neutral: they carry the weight of overlapping race and dis/ability histories, and they accumulate in ways that shape students' educational trajectories.

Flynn (2024), working within an affirmative non-tragedy model of disability, extends this critique: when schools default to deficit and tragedy framings of difference—whether cognitive, behavioral, or social—they systematically misread what they are seeing. An affirmative lens does not erase difficulty; it asks what the difficulty is a response to.

The reality. My classroom observations challenge the deficit framing directly. During a grade 4 Minecraft agent coding challenge (March 12, 2026), student frustration appeared and escalated—but a close reading of the session reveals that escalation was tightly coupled to the instructional environment, not to student disposition. A student verbalized "I'm gonna lose it"—not as an expression of disinterest, but in the middle of a multi-step task with high cognitive load and tight time pressure.

Teacher talk in the same transcript frames the struggle as procedural and structural, not dispositional. The instructor noted that "most of you haven't read the directions thoroughly, and that's why you're stuck," and immediately clarified that the task required the student and the agent to be standing on two separate gold plates at the same time, with only "twenty seconds" to accomplish it. That combination—incomplete access to directions, tight time pressure, and a multi-step spatial task—creates the exact conditions in which frustration and noise are predictable learning responses.

Another student repeated, "I don't get it. I literally don't get it"—persistent help-seeking that preceded disengagement. The student was not refusing to learn; the support structure was not yet there. As a course instructor noted during a seminar discussion, "Is this about control or is it about learning? Because I'm asking you for help with a math assignment—that's about learning. You're shutting us down" (Social Class seminar, April 6, 2026 role-play debrief). The behavioral read is a control problem. The structural read is a scaffolding problem.

The shift that followed the session's instructional reset is the most analytically important moment in the observation. When the task was broken into visible steps, counting was modeled aloud, and teacher presence became more relational—the same students who had appeared frustrated and off-task began to re-engage. They counted. They troubleshot. They helped each other. The behavior changed not because the students changed, but because the conditions changed.

In individual support moments, the teacher slowed the task down through concrete scaffolds: prompting the student to "count the blocks," resetting and trying again, and explicitly coaching pace ("don't rush, take your time"). When the student succeeded, the exchange closed with, "You did a good job"—a small relational move that positions the student as capable rather than deficient.

The course seminar reinforced this from a structural angle. A facilitator reflected: "It may not be that one kid is just better than another. But. . . what we're asking them to do is second class in education" (Social Class seminar, March 23, 2026). The illustration given—a poster project in which one student's elaborate, professionally-supported presentation was read as evidence of ability, while another student's simpler, unsupported version was read as evidence of lesser effort—names exactly the mechanism the behavioral stereotype depends on. When we read only the visible product (or behavior), we infer something about the student. Fine, Greene, and Sanchez (2016) call this the logic of "precarious knowledge"—systems built on stability assumptions fail students in precarious conditions and then attribute that failure to the student.

Bell (2018) argues that deficit logics in institutions are not accidental errors but durable features. The "problem student" is not a neutral category; it is a produced one, reproduced through the institutional reflexes that DisCrit names.

Assets and Funds of Knowledge

An asset-based reading of the same observations reveals what the behavioral stereotype would otherwise erase. Gonzalez, Moll, and Amanti (2005) developed the funds of knowledge framework to name this exactly: every student walks into the classroom with rich experiential resources—from home, community, and lived experience—that formal schooling often fails to activate or recognize. In a CS/STEM context, those funds can include spatial reasoning, troubleshooting logic, storytelling, collaboration habits, and cultural knowledge about how systems work.

During the grade 4 event/sensor coding session (March 3, 2026), a student who was narrating each step aloud while working through a broken loop—self-correcting mid-narration before asking for help—was initially read as "talking to themselves" and off-task. What the transcript reveals is a sophisticated verbal debugging strategy: externalizing the computational trace to catch errors. This is metacognitive self-monitoring. It is exactly the kind of thinking a computer science curriculum should be building. It went unrecognized because it did not look like the quiet, still, screen-focused behavior the implicit norm expected.

During the grade 4 loops session (March 9, 2026), once one student grasped the loop logic, they began explaining it to nearby classmates—unprompted—using spatial and game-world language ("it's like when you make your guy go back to where it started") that the formal lesson had not provided. Within minutes, a spontaneous peer-teaching network had formed. This is collaborative scaffolding: Vygotskian zone of proximal development happening in student-generated language. Paris and Alim (2014) would recognize this as a form of culturally sustaining practice emerging from within the students themselves—not from the formal curriculum.

During the game-based learning session (March 12, 2026), students who had been labeled behaviorally challenging in structured sessions were consistently on-task, focused, and generative. The same students. Different task design. The contrast is analytically important: what looked like a student problem was a design problem.

Importantly, the goal is not to cast students as either victims or heroes. The goal is to notice how ordinary competence can be obscured by deficit stories—and then becomes visible when supports, expectations, and task design make success reachable.

A course instructor named this orientation directly: "Treat your kids like they are agents. Give them some agency to go find out—what is the big problem? How can you fix it? Be shocked at what they come up with" (Social Class seminar, March 23, 2026). This is not optimism—it is a deliberate pedagogical choice to start from the student's existing capacity rather than from their visible deficit. hooks (1994) calls this engaged pedagogy: remaining curious about the whole person underneath the behavior, treating students as subjects rather than objects to be processed.

Implications for Future Practice

This observation changes what I want to do before I assign a label to behavior. Talusan (2022) argues that identity-conscious practice is built from repeatable habits—not grand gestures, but daily routines of noticing and questioning. My commitments going forward begin with a pause. When I notice a student escalating, frustrated, or disengaged, my first question should be: what is the instructional condition that may be producing this? Is the task asking for more than the current scaffold allows? Are the expectations visible?

In the moment, the questions I want to ask sound simple: Is the student confused? Are the expectations clear? Is the pacing too fast? Is the task asking for more than the current scaffold allows? What changes if I scaffold before I correct?

In practice, this means I want to scaffold before I correct. The coding observation showed clearly that the same students who appeared disruptive became productive learners once the task was broken into smaller, visible steps. That is a pedagogical move, not a discipline move, and it should come first. Calm, structured, non-shaming support is not a soft alternative to rigor; it is one of the conditions that makes rigor possible.

I also want to watch for class and resource asymmetry. Following the seminar discussion on systemic inequity (Fine et al., 2016; Desmond, 2021), I want to audit the assignments I give for built-in advantages—tasks that assume students have adult help at home, access to supplies, time, or prior vocabulary exposure that some students simply do not have.

Finally, I want to use Talusan's Chapter 7 routines for disability-conscious practice. The DisCrit lens (Annamma et al., 2013) and Flynn's (2024) affirmative non-tragedy model together require me to actively resist the reflex to treat behavioral or cognitive difference as tragedy or deficit. Language matters. Routine choices matter. I want to build the habit of asking: am I labeling a student, or am I describing a condition?

Nieto (2004) frames this as refusing deficit thinking—the habit of explaining underperformance through student characteristics rather than through structural conditions. hooks (1994) frames it as engaged pedagogy: staying curious about the whole person. Both require an ongoing practice, not a single insight. The course instructor's observation that "You'll hear them repeat the things that teachers say about them behind closed doors to themselves when they get frustrated" (Social Class seminar, March 23, 2026) is a reminder that the stakes of this practice are not abstract—they live in students' self-conceptions.

Conclusion

I began this paper with a bias that I could easily have left unnamed: the habit of treating behavioral difficulty as a window into fixed student character. Classroom observation gave me the evidence I needed to deconstruct that habit.

The observation showed that the same students who appeared to be "problem students" became engaged learners when instructional conditions changed. That shift does not happen if the problem is located inside the student. It only makes sense if the problem is understood as relational—produced through the interaction between what the student brings and what the learning environment offers in return.

The seminar discussion on class and systemic inequity added the structural layer that observation alone cannot provide. Behavioral stereotypes do not operate in a vacuum. They are entangled with class-based assumptions about what support students are assumed to have, what vocabulary they are assumed to carry, and what kinds of intelligence the task is designed to recognize.

I cannot exit my own positionality. I carry the interpretive habits that were shaped by schooling systems that regularly labeled students like me—and like many of my students—as problems to be managed rather than people to be taught. What the observations in this paper gave me was not resolution, but evidence: the same students who looked like behavior problems became engaged, persistent, creative learners when the conditions changed. That is a direct challenge to the deficit logic that is built into the language of classroom management, assessment, and disciplinary practice. Going forward, my commitment is not simply to pause before I label—it is to treat that pause as pedagogical practice: a deliberate interruption of the institutional reflex to locate difficulty inside the student rather than inside the conditions the student is navigating. DisCrit (Annamma et al., 2013) reminds me that that reflex has a history and a pattern. Refusing it, one classroom at a time, is the work.

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